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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Pappas held stock in firm with county deal

Cook treasurer's interest in Tyler Technologies could violate ethics rule

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Cook County Treasurer Maria Pappas held stock for years in a company with a major contract working in her office, a potential violation of the county's conflict-of-interest rules.

Pappas has been one of the most vociferous critics of Tyler Technologies, the company that has been in charge of the rocky upgrade of the county's property tax system, for more than a decade. Tyler has been embedded in the treasurer's office, which calculates and mails out property tax bills, for years.

The problematic rollout of Tyler's tax system revamp within county offices led to late property tax bills last year and problems distributing property tax revenues in recent months to local agencies like schools and libraries.

But while she was hammering Tyler, Pappas owned stock in the company. Pappas' office shared statements from her broker that show 10 Tyler shares were purchased in 2020, and four more in 2022. Together, they cost \$4,562. Tyler first received the county contract in 2015.

Pappas said she was not aware of the investment, which was made by a former broker, and sold them in March of 2024. And following a Tribune inquiry, she also sold stock for other companies doing business with the county, including the bank providing lockbox and collection services for the treasurer, her office said.

Those investments were some of the 30 to 40 assets, including individual stocks and exchange-traded funds, that Pappas disclosed in annual statements of economic interest between 2021 and 2024. Under state law, officials are required to disclose those worth more than \$10,000.

Even though the holdings were less than \$10,000, Pappas' office said she reported them anyway "in the interest of transparency," but suggested she did not review them closely.

"When she realized they were in her portfolio, she instructed her new broker to sell the shares immediately," spokesman Michael Puccinelli said of the Tyler stock in an emailed statement. She submitted her economic interest statements without noticing Tyler on the list, he said, and when she did, she asked her new broker to sell.

After the Tribune asked this week about the Tyler stock or

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INSIDE

Cook County Board president wants agents charged

President Toni Preckwinkle and some commissioners called Thursday for the state's attorney to prosecute federal agents involved in two local shootings. **Page 2**

Buzelis is new face of the Bulls as team rebuilds

After a tumultuous trade deadline, forward Matas Buzelis is the primary option for the Bulls as the team takes the first step toward redefining its identity. **Chicago Sports**



Rush hour traffic moves on the Kennedy Expressway in Chicago. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Trump's EPA repeals science behind climate change fight

Move dismantles ability to limit greenhouse gases; environmentalists vow appeal

By Jerry Wu
Chicago Tribune

The Trump administration on Thursday repealed the scientific determination that underpins federal greenhouse gas regulations, delivering one of the most dramatic reversals of U.S. climate policy.

For months, the administration has signaled its plans to go after the 2009 endangerment finding, the determination by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency concluding that several greenhouse gases pose a threat to public health and welfare. That finding has since provided

the legal basis for most federal emission regulations for vehicles, power plants and other sources under the Clean Air Act.

"The Trump EPA has finalized the single largest act of deregulation in the history of the United States of America," EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin announced at the White House. "The 2009 Obama EPA endangerment finding led to trillions of dollars in regulations that strangled entire sectors of the United States economy, including the American auto industry."

The reversal drew an immediate outcry from environmentalists and other critics, who said it comes as climate change intensi-

fies. In the Midwest, this is fueling extreme heat, toxic algal blooms in the Great Lakes and tornadoes across Illinois. The move is widely expected to upend numerous U.S. policies aimed at curbing pollution.

"This is a really profound and utter rejection of decades of scientific consensus. It shows a willingness to sacrifice the lives of Americans to boost the profits of the oil industry," said the Sierra Club's Illinois Chapter Director Jack Darin. "Just like we regulate ozone or particulate matter or lead, we need to be protected from carbon and other greenhouse gases as well."

The final rule will remove all federal regulations to measure and report federal greenhouse gas emission standards for motor vehicles. It also will repeal all compliance programs, credit provisions and other similar reporting requirements in the vehicle industry.

Zeldin said Thursday that the rule will save more than \$1.3 trillion in taxpayer money and reduce costs by up to \$2,400 for popular light-duty cars, SUVs and trucks "What that means is lower prices, more choices and an end to heavy-handed climate policies," he said.

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U.S. Rep. Darin LaHood, 16th, questions Mayor Brandon Johnson March 5 during a hearing on Capitol Hill about sanctuary cities and immigration policy. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Illinois Republicans weigh fealty to Trump amid backlash, shutdown threat

By Daniel C. Vock
and Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — House Republicans have used a slim majority to push through some of President Donald Trump's biggest priorities — and shield him from political and legal trouble — since Trump returned to the White House last year.

But as Trump's approval ratings slide and the federal government faces a partial shutdown this weekend, their united

front is showing hairline cracks.

Republicans hold a 218-214 majority in the House, with three vacant seats. Such a narrow margin means only a handful of disgruntled GOP members are needed to deal a defeat to their party leadership.

Republican House members bucked Trump and U.S. House Speaker Mike Johnson repeatedly in recent weeks. They forced a vote to repeal Trump's Canadian tariffs, mandated the

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Convict's online dating efforts spark anger

Man freed in murder case says posts about him are misleading

By Christy Gutowski
Chicago Tribune

A convicted murderer's recent foray into online dating is causing a stir on social media, where outraged commenters who learned of his connection to a grisly 1993 suburban slaying are warning women in search of love to swipe left.

Paul Modrowski was 18 years old when prosecutors charged him and a co-defendant with the murder of a friend, Dean Fawcett, whose headless body was discovered months earlier near railroad tracks in Barrington.

A jury later convicted Modrowski under the legal theory of accountability, as authorities were unable to prove he was there when the victim was killed. But, after serving more than 30 years of a natural life sentence, Modrowski won back his freedom in summer 2024 when a judge ruled he had been too harshly punished and resented him to a 60-year term.

Under sentencing laws in place at the time of the crime, Modrowski was eligible for day-for-day credit, allowing for his release days later. In the last 18 months, the now 51-year-old



Paul Modrowski is shown in a photo posted on his blog with a public statement about online comments criticizing his participation in dating platforms. **PAUL MODROWSKI**

Modrowski has earned a bachelor's degree from Northwestern University in Evanston, where he is working as an academic researcher, and appears to be living a relatively quiet life.

That changed earlier this week when internet sleuths found him on the League, a popular online dating app, and began sharing screenshots of his dating profile across various social media platforms. The profile includes Modrowski's photo, first name, town, the incorrect age of 37, and an "about me" bio that reads: "Astrophysics by day & good vibes by night. Match if you want to connect."

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